

THE REBIRTH OF EUROPE

The Renaissance began in northern Italy towards the end of the 14th century. Two hundred years later, its influence had spread all over the world.

c.1420

Architect Filippo Brunelleschi rediscovers perspective, meaning that objects can be drawn to look as if they are near or far away.

Arches drawn using perspective



1440

Johannes Gutenberg invents the printing press in Germany.



First printing press

1469

Lorenzo de Medici becomes head of the city-state of Florence.



Statue of Lorenzo de Medici

1472

Artist Leonardo da Vinci, aged only 20, is invited to join the Painters' Guild of Florence.

1486

Botticelli paints his masterpiece *The Birth of Venus*.

1498

Leonardo paints the mural *The Last Supper* for a convent in Milan.



Statue on the tomb of Pope Julius II

1503

Pope Julius II commissions many artists, including Michelangelo and Raphael, to create work for him in Rome.

1504

Michelangelo's statue of David is displayed in Florence.



1509

Dutch scholar Erasmus publishes his book *Praise of Folly*, which pokes fun at superstition.

1511

Raphael completes the fresco *The School of Athens* to decorate a wall in the Vatican, the Pope's palace.

1527

Rome is sacked by the army of Charles V, the Holy Roman Emperor.

1543

Doctor Andrea Vesalius publishes the first textbook about the human body and how it works.



Woodcut portrait of Andreas Vesalius

1546

Michelangelo appointed chief architect at St Peter's Basilica, Rome.

1550

Giorgio Vasari publishes a massive history of Renaissance art: *The Lives of the Artists*.

The Renaissance

The Renaissance is the name given to a time of huge cultural change in Europe, beginning in the late 14th century. Scholars rediscovered the writings of the Ancient Greeks and Romans, and this led to an explosion of new ideas about science, art, and politics.

WHERE IT BEGAN

The Renaissance began in the richest parts of Europe. The city-states of northern Italy were full of wealthy noblemen, bankers, and merchants who were eager to show off their wealth and power by supporting artists and inventors. In northern Europe, scholarship and new ideas flourished in the prosperous wool-trading regions of what is now Belgium, Germany, and the Netherlands.

KEY

• Major Renaissance cities



POWERFUL PATRONS

The Medici family were rich bankers. From 1434 they ruled the city of Florence, and commissioned artists such as Leonardo da Vinci and Michelangelo to produce many great buildings and works of art.



MEDICI COAT OF ARMS

LEONARDO DESIGNED RECOGNIZABLE VERSIONS OF THE MODERN BICYCLE, HELICOPTER, AND PARACHUTE

SCIENCE AND DISCOVERY

A new method of approaching science began to take hold during the Renaissance, in which conducting experiments and gathering evidence were seen as the best ways to gain knowledge. This approach led to great progress in the sciences and to many new inventions.



PRINTED BOOK

Printing meant that scholars could publish their work more widely and exchange ideas with each other.



THEODOLITE

An instrument to help architects and builders to measure angles.



ASTROLABE

An ancient navigation aid, redesigned and widely used by Renaissance explorers.

FLYING MACHINE

Leonardo da Vinci's design for the ornithopter, a human-powered aircraft.



MATCHLOCK MUSKET

The matchlock was a new way of firing a gun so that it could be operated by a single person.



WHEEL LOCK PISTOL

A method for firing the gun mechanically, rather than by a lit wick, it was safer and more portable than the matchlock weapon.

RENAISSANCE MEN

During the Renaissance, many of the most influential people did not focus solely on one subject, but became expert in a range of disciplines.

LEONARDO DA VINCI (1452–1519)

A true all-rounder, Leonardo was a brilliant painter, inventor, sculptor, architect, and scientist. His *Mona Lisa* is probably the best-known painting in history.

MARTIN LUTHER (1483–1546)

German monk and university professor. He attacked corruption in the Roman Catholic Church, was excommunicated, and became a key figure in the Protestant Reformation.

PARACELSUS (1493–1541)

Swiss scientist who studied medicine and found that many doctors made patients worse rather than healing them. He used his knowledge of chemistry to develop new drugs and medicines.

MICHELANGELO (1475–1564)

Artist, architect, and sculptor who painted the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel, part of the Vatican in Rome. The ceiling contains more than 400 life-size figures and took four years to complete.

NICCOLO MACHIAVELLI (1469–1527)

A diplomat and writer from Florence. His book *The Prince* gave advice to ambitious politicians on how to succeed. The word "machievellian" is still used today to describe ruthless or cunning behaviour.